## The Rise of Liu Bang

After the collapse of the Qin Dynasty, the country found itself in a state of chaos. Two generals who became famous at this time are known as Liu Bang from Hanzhong and King Xiang Yu from Chu. Both of them fought tooth and claw to seize control of the throne. Xiang Yu had gained a reputation as a fierce warrior when he fought against the Qin. Similarly, Liu Bang had earned the title King of the Han after defeating the Qin. They were allies initially but soon found themselves opposing each other. They mutually decided to sign the Treaty of Hong Canal, which resulted in peace for a short time.

Xiang Yu proposed that they divide the country into two sections where Chu would rule the east and Han would rule the west. However, Liu Bang did not want the country to be split and broke the truce by attacking Xiang Yu's armies. In 202 BCE, they met at the Battle of Gaixia where Liu Bang's general was able to defeat the Chu army. Liu Bang declared himself as emperor and later became known as Emperor Gaozu. When Xiang Yu saw that he was losing the battle, he committed suicide. The remaining members of his family were permitted to live and were given posts in the new government. Liu Bang is known for showing respect to his enemies and for reuniting the country.  Firstly, the new emperor expelled those tribes who had supported Xiang Yu during the war. Secondly, he formalized treaties with the other independent states that had opposed the Qin. Except for a short disruption from Wang Meng, the Han Dynasty ruled the country successfully for the next four centuries.